

Scale Factor Confusion: Linear, Square, Cubic

Answer Key

High School Geometry

Quick Answers

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|----------|--------------------------------|
| 1. 108 | 4. $\frac{5}{3}, -\frac{5}{3}$ |
| 2. 432 | 5. 2 |
| 3. 112.5 | 6. — |
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Curriculum

Level: High School Geometry

HSG-SRT.A.1–A.3, HSG-SRT.B.4–B.5 – *problems 1, 2, 3, 4, 5, 6*

Difficulty 1–5 of 5 across 6 tagged checks.

Common wrong answers

1. If they got 36: multiplied the area by the linear scale factor instead of by its square
 2. If they got 108: multiplied the volume by the linear scale factor instead of by its cube
 2. If they got 216: used the square of the factor, the rule for areas, on a volume
 3. If they got 45: scaled the area by the linear ratio instead of by its square
 5. If they got 8: reported the volume ratio itself as the linear scale factor
 5. If they got 2.83: took the square root of the volume ratio, the rule for areas
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The single idea being tested: the exponent on the scale factor counts *dimensions*. Lengths scale by k , areas by k^2 , volumes by k^3 ; running the rule backwards takes the matching root. Every wrong answer on this sheet is the right factor raised to the wrong power.

1. Area 12 after a dilation with $k = 3$.

A dilation multiplies every length by k , and an area is built from two perpendicular lengths, so both of them stretch: the area is multiplied by $k \cdot k = k^2$.

$$A' = 12 \cdot 3^2 = 12 \cdot 9$$

So the image has area 108 cm².

Watch for: $12 \cdot 3 = 36$, which scales the area as if it were a length.

2. Similar cones, linear factor 2, smaller volume 54.

A volume is built from three perpendicular lengths, and a dilation stretches all three, so the volume is multiplied by $k \cdot k \cdot k = k^3$. With $k = 2$, that factor is 8.

$$V' = 54 \cdot 2^3 = 54 \cdot 8$$

The larger cone holds $\boxed{432 \text{ cm}^3}$.

Watch for: 108 (the factor used once, as if volume were a length) and 216 (the factor squared, which is the rule for areas).

3. Find the mistake: similar triangles, 5 : 2, smaller area 18.

(a) Rey used the *linear* ratio on an *area*. The ratio 5 : 2 compares corresponding sides, so it scales lengths. Area needs the square of that ratio, because both dimensions of the triangle grow.

(b) Correct work: $k = \frac{5}{2}$, so the area ratio is $k^2 = \frac{25}{4}$, and

$$A_{\text{larger}} = 18 \cdot \left(\frac{5}{2}\right)^2 = 18 \cdot \frac{25}{4} = \frac{450}{4}$$

which gives $\boxed{112.5 \text{ cm}^2}$.

Sanity check: the larger triangle is more than twice as long in each direction, so more than a doubling of area is expected — and 112.5 is more than six times 18, while Rey's 45 was only two and a half times.

4. Areas in the ratio 25 : 9: solve $9k^2 = 25$.

(a) The equation says the area ratio is the *square* of the linear factor, so isolate k^2 and take roots. Squaring destroys sign information, so the equation has two solutions:

$$k^2 = \frac{25}{9} \quad k = \pm \sqrt{\frac{25}{9}}$$

which are $\boxed{k = \frac{5}{3}}$ and $\boxed{k = -\frac{5}{3}}$.

(b) A scale factor multiplies lengths, and lengths are positive, so only $k = \frac{5}{3}$ describes a pair of similar figures; the negative root is an artifact of squaring and is rejected. As a check, $\left(\frac{5}{3}\right)^2 = \frac{25}{9}$, the given area ratio.

5. Find the mistake: similar cylinders of volume 250 and 2000.

(a) Nia reported the *volume* ratio as if it were the linear factor: $2000/250 = 8$ is k^3 , not k . Kim took a square root, which is the rule for going back from an *area* ratio; on a volume ratio it gives about 2.83, a number that is neither the linear factor nor anything else in the problem.

(b) Volume ratio is k^3 , so the linear factor is the *cube* root:

$$k^3 = \frac{2000}{250} = 8 \quad k = \sqrt[3]{8}$$

The correct linear scale factor is $k = 2$.

Check it forwards: $250 \cdot 2^3 = 2000$, which is exactly the larger volume, so the factor is confirmed — a check neither student ran.

6. “Double every edge: twice the paint, twice the sand.” (open response — read the sketch and the reasoning)

The claim is wrong in both halves, and by different amounts. With every edge doubled the linear scale factor is $k = 2$. Paint covers the outside, which is surface area, so it scales by $k^2 = 4$: the box needs four times as much paint. Sand fills the inside, which is volume, so it scales by $k^3 = 8$: it holds eight times as much sand. Only a *length* — an edge, a diagonal, the perimeter of a face — doubles.

paint $\times 4$, sand $\times 8$

Full credit shows a sketch of the original box and the doubled box with edges labelled, states k^2 for surface area and k^3 for volume, and explains that the exponent counts how many dimensions are being stretched at once (a face is stretched in two directions, the interior in three). *Not full credit:* the numbers 4 and 8 with no link to dimensions, or a claim that only the volume changes.